

06-cinco-de-mayo-cross-curricular

Cinco de Mayo Cultural Reading & Math Fiesta — Full Content

Visual Design Notes

- **Color Palette:** Vibrant magenta, turquoise, marigold yellow, lime green, orange
 - **Style:** Papel picado (perforated paper banner) borders, marigold flower accents, folkart-inspired patterns
 - **Layout:** Reading passages on left-side pages, math on right — creating a “book” feel
 - **Fonts:** Festive but readable — bold rounded headers, clean body text
 - **Cultural elements:** Papel picado banners, marigold flowers, traditional tile patterns (Talavera-inspired)
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Reading Passage 1: What is Cinco de Mayo Really About?

Passage (Lexile 780-840)

If you ask most people in the United States what Cinco de Mayo is, they might say “Mexican Independence Day.” But that’s actually not correct! Cinco de Mayo celebrates something very different — and the real story is even more exciting.

Cinco de Mayo, which means “the fifth of May” in Spanish, celebrates the Battle of Puebla on May 5, 1862. On that day, the Mexican army defeated the French army in the city of Puebla, Mexico. What makes this so remarkable is that the French were considered the most powerful military in the world at the time. The Mexican army was much smaller, less equipped, and not expected to win. But they did.

Mexico owed money to several European countries, including France. When Mexico couldn’t pay, France’s emperor, Napoleon III, decided to invade Mexico and take control

of the country. He sent thousands of well-trained, well-armed French soldiers to Mexico.

General Ignacio Zaragoza led the Mexican forces at Puebla. Though his army was smaller and had fewer weapons, they used their knowledge of the local terrain — the hills, valleys, and muddy fields — to their advantage. Against all odds, they defeated the French that day.

It's important to know that this was one battle, not the end of the war. France eventually took control of parts of Mexico for a few years before being pushed out. And Mexican Independence Day is actually September 16, not May 5.

So why do we celebrate Cinco de Mayo so enthusiastically in the United States? The holiday became popular among Mexican Americans as a celebration of Mexican culture, heritage, and the spirit of standing up against impossible odds. In Texas, Cinco de Mayo has been celebrated since the 1860s — making it one of the longest-running cultural celebrations in the state!

Today, Cinco de Mayo is a day to celebrate Mexican-American culture with music, dancing, food, and community. It's a reminder that courage and determination can overcome even the greatest challenges.

Comprehension Questions

1. What does Cinco de Mayo ACTUALLY celebrate?
 - A. Mexican Independence from Spain
 - B. The victory of the Mexican army over the French at the Battle of Puebla
 - C. The birthday of a Mexican president
 - D. The end of the Mexican-American War
2. Why was the Mexican victory at Puebla so surprising?
 - A. The French army didn't know how to fight
 - B. The Mexican army was much smaller and less equipped than the French
 - C. It was raining that day
 - D. The battle only lasted a few minutes
3. The word "terrain" in paragraph 4 most likely means —
 - A. a type of weapon
 - B. the physical features of the land

- C. a military strategy
 - D. the name of a city
4. According to the passage, why is Cinco de Mayo celebrated more in the U.S. than in Mexico?
- A. Because it became a celebration of Mexican-American culture and heritage in the U.S.
 - B. Because the battle took place in the United States
 - C. Because Americans won the battle
 - D. Because Mexico doesn't allow celebrations
5. (Short Answer) How is Cinco de Mayo different from Mexican Independence Day? Use details from the passage.

Math Word Problems Set 1: Battle Math

1. General Zaragoza had 4,500 Mexican soldiers. The French had 6,500 soldiers. How many MORE soldiers did the French have? (Answer: 2,000)
2. If the Mexican army marched 18 miles per day for 5 days to reach Puebla, how many total miles did they march? (Answer: 90 miles)
3. The battle lasted about 4 hours. If cannons fired every 15 minutes, how many times did the cannons fire during the battle? (Answer: 16 times)
4. (Gr 4-5) After the battle, 462 French soldiers were captured. If they were put in groups of 6, how many full groups could be formed? How many soldiers would be left over? (Answer: 77 groups, 0 left over)
5. (Gr 5) The French army brought 3,200 pounds of supplies. They used $\frac{2}{5}$ of the supplies before the battle. How many pounds did they use? How many pounds were left? (Answer: Used 1,280 lbs; Left 1,920 lbs)

Reading Passage 2: The Tejano Contribution — Mexican-American Culture in Texas

Passage (Lexile 790-850)

Long before Texas was part of the United States — and even before it was the Republic of Texas — it was part of Mexico. The Mexican and Spanish settlers who lived in Texas before and during this time are known as Tejanos, and their contributions to Texas culture are everywhere, even if you don't always realize it.

The word “Tejano” comes from the Spanish word for “Texan.” Tejano families have lived in Texas for hundreds of years. Cities like San Antonio, El Paso, and Laredo were founded by Spanish and Mexican settlers long before English-speaking settlers arrived. In fact, San Antonio was founded in 1718 — more than 100 years before Stephen F. Austin brought his colonists to Texas.

Tejano culture is woven into the fabric of Texas life. Many of the foods Texans love — tacos, tamales, enchiladas, salsa, and tortillas — come from Mexican and Tejano traditions. The ranching techniques that made Texas famous, including cattle branding and the use of lassos, were developed by Mexican vaqueros (cowboys). The American cowboy learned from the vaquero!

Tejano music is another beautiful contribution. It blends Mexican folk music with polka, rock, and other styles. Artists like Selena Quintanilla, who grew up in Corpus Christi, Texas, brought Tejano music to audiences around the world. Selena became one of the most beloved musicians in Texas history.

Architecture in Texas also shows Tejano influence. The Spanish missions, including the famous Alamo in San Antonio, were built in the Spanish colonial style. Many Texas homes, churches, and public buildings feature stucco walls, tile roofs, and courtyards that come from Spanish and Mexican building traditions.

Today, Mexican Americans make up nearly 40% of the Texas population, making them the largest ethnic group in the state. Tejano culture isn't just part of Texas history — it IS Texas history.

Comprehension Questions

1. What is the MAIN idea of this passage?
 - A. Tejano music is popular in Texas
 - B. Mexican-American culture has deeply shaped Texas in many ways
 - C. San Antonio was founded in 1718

- D. Tejanos lived in Texas before English-speaking settlers
2. What can the reader INFER about the relationship between vaqueros and American cowboys?
- A. They were enemies
 - B. American cowboys invented ranching
 - C. American cowboys learned ranching techniques from Mexican vaqueros
 - D. Vaqueros only worked in Mexico
3. The author includes the detail about San Antonio being founded in 1718 to —
- A. show that Tejano presence in Texas is much older than many people realize
 - B. prove that San Antonio is the best city in Texas
 - C. explain why Stephen F. Austin came to Texas
 - D. describe how cities are founded
4. (Short Answer) Name THREE specific contributions of Tejano culture to Texas, according to the passage.

Math Word Problems Set 2: Culture by the Numbers

1. A family makes 144 tamales for Cinco de Mayo. They put 12 tamales in each container. How many containers do they need? (Answer: 12)
2. Selena's album sold 175,000 copies in Texas. It sold 3 times as many copies across the rest of the U.S. How many total copies sold? (Answer: $175,000 + 525,000 = 700,000$)
3. A Tejano band plays for 2 hours and 45 minutes. How many total minutes is that? (Answer: 165 minutes)
4. (Gr 4-5) San Antonio was founded in 1718. Texas became a state in 1845. How many years was San Antonio part of Mexico/Spain before Texas became a state? (Answer: 127 years)
5. (Gr 5) If Mexican Americans make up 39.7% of the Texas population of about 30,000,000 people, approximately how many Mexican Americans live in Texas? (Answer: about 11,910,000)
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Reading Passage 3: Mariachi — The Music of Celebration

Passage (Lexile 770-830)

If you’ve ever been to a Mexican restaurant, a quinceañera, or a Cinco de Mayo celebration, you’ve probably heard the sound of mariachi music. With its trumpets, violins, and guitars, mariachi is one of the most recognizable and joyful musical traditions in the world.

Mariachi music originated in western Mexico, in the state of Jalisco, during the 1800s. The word “mariachi” originally referred to the platform or stage where musicians performed. Over time, it came to mean the musicians themselves and their style of music.

A traditional mariachi group includes violins, trumpets, a Spanish guitar, a vihuela (a small round-backed guitar), and a guitarrón (a large bass guitar). The musicians wear elegant traje de charro — suits decorated with silver buttons and embroidery. These outfits are based on the clothing of Mexican horsemen called charros.

Mariachi songs tell stories about love, nature, patriotism, and everyday life. Some songs are happy and fast, perfect for dancing. Others are slow and emotional, expressing deep feelings. One of the most famous mariachi songs is “Cielito Lindo,” which includes the famous chorus “Ay, ay, ay, ay, canta y no llores” (“Sing and don’t cry”).

In Texas, mariachi is everywhere. Many schools have mariachi programs where students learn to play in the mariachi tradition. The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley has one of the most respected collegiate mariachi programs in the country. San Antonio hosts an annual Mariachi Festival that draws musicians from across the Americas.

In 2011, UNESCO (the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization) added mariachi to its list of Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. This means the entire world recognizes mariachi as an important cultural treasure worth protecting.

Whether it’s a wedding, a birthday, a holiday, or just a Tuesday evening, mariachi music has the power to bring people together and fill any space with joy.

Comprehension Questions

1. What instruments are used in a traditional mariachi group?

- A. Drums, piano, and flute
 - B. Violins, trumpets, guitar, vihuela, and guitarrón
 - C. Only guitars and trumpets
 - D. Electronic instruments
2. Why did UNESCO add mariachi to its cultural heritage list?
- A. Because mariachi is very loud
 - B. Because the world recognizes it as an important cultural treasure
 - C. Because mariachi musicians wear special outfits
 - D. Because mariachi is only played in Mexico
3. Based on the passage, the reader can conclude that mariachi music is —
- A. only popular in Mexico
 - B. dying out and being forgotten
 - C. a living, growing tradition celebrated in Texas and worldwide
 - D. only played at Cinco de Mayo celebrations
4. (Short Answer) How does the passage show that mariachi is an important part of Texas culture? Give TWO examples.

Math Word Problems Set 3: Musical Math

1. A mariachi group has 3 violins, 2 trumpets, 1 guitar, 1 vihuela, and 1 guitarrón. How many musicians are in the group? (Answer: 8)
2. The group plays 4 songs per set and plays 3 sets at a party. Each song is about 5 minutes long. How many total minutes of music do they play? (Answer: 60 minutes)
3. A mariachi suit costs \$450. Silver buttons for decoration cost \$12 each. If a suit has 35 buttons, what is the total cost of the suit with buttons? (Answer: $\$450 + \$420 = \$870$)
4. (Gr 4-5) At the San Antonio Mariachi Festival, 1,250 people attend on Friday, 2,380 on Saturday, and 1,875 on Sunday. What is the total attendance? What is the average daily attendance? (Answer: Total = 5,505; Average = 1,835)
5. (Gr 5) A school mariachi program has 24 students. $\frac{1}{3}$ play violin, $\frac{1}{4}$ play trumpet, and the rest play guitar instruments. How many students play guitar instruments? (Answer: $8 \text{ violin} + 6 \text{ trumpet} = 14$; $24 - 14 = 10$ guitar instruments)

Reading Passage 4: Frida Kahlo & Mexican Art in Texas

Passage (Lexile 780-840)

Walk through any Texas city and you'll see it — vibrant murals on building walls, colorful art in galleries, and bold designs on everything from pottery to clothing. Much of this artistic spirit comes from Mexican and Mexican-American art traditions, and one of the most famous artists connected to this tradition is Frida Kahlo.

Frida Kahlo was born in 1907 in Coyoacán, Mexico. As a teenager, she was in a terrible bus accident that left her with lifelong injuries. During her long recovery, she began to paint. Art became her way of expressing her pain, her joy, and her identity.

Frida is best known for her self-portraits — paintings of herself. But these weren't ordinary self-portraits. Frida filled her paintings with symbols from Mexican folk art: flowers, animals, bright colors, and references to Mexico's indigenous (native) cultures. She proudly wore traditional Mexican clothing and incorporated pre-Columbian art styles into her work.

Frida's art was revolutionary because she painted her real life — including her suffering, her Mexican heritage, and her identity as a woman — at a time when most famous artists were men painting landscapes and historical scenes. She showed the world that personal stories and cultural identity are worthy subjects for great art.

In Texas, Frida Kahlo's influence is everywhere. Mexican-American muralists across the state create large, colorful public artworks that tell the stories of their communities. In San Antonio, Houston, Austin, and El Paso, you can find stunning murals celebrating Mexican-American history, culture, and identity. These murals are influenced by Frida and by other great Mexican muralists like Diego Rivera and David Alfaro Siqueiros.

The tradition of folk art — handmade pottery, textiles, papel picado (perforated paper banners), and piñatas — is also alive and well in Texas. At markets and festivals across the state, artisans create beautiful works that connect modern Texas to centuries-old Mexican artistic traditions.

Art has the power to tell stories, preserve culture, and bring communities together. The Mexican and Mexican-American art traditions in Texas do all three.

Comprehension Questions

1. According to the passage, what made Frida Kahlo's art revolutionary?
 - A. She only painted landscapes
 - B. She painted personal stories and her cultural identity when most famous artists were men painting other subjects
 - C. She was the first person to paint self-portraits
 - D. She used very expensive paint
2. The word "indigenous" in paragraph 3 means —
 - A. foreign or from another country
 - B. native or originally from a place
 - C. a type of painting style
 - D. old-fashioned
3. How does the passage connect Frida Kahlo to Texas?
 - A. Frida Kahlo lived in Texas
 - B. Her artistic influence can be seen in the murals and art traditions throughout Texas
 - C. She painted a picture of Texas
 - D. Her paintings are only displayed in Texas museums
4. (Short Answer) Why does the author say "Art has the power to tell stories, preserve culture, and bring communities together"? Use examples from the passage to support this idea.

Math Word Problems Set 4: Art by Numbers

1. An artist uses 3 cans of paint for a small mural and 8 cans for a large mural. If she paints 5 small murals and 2 large murals, how many cans of paint does she need?
(Answer: $15 + 16 = 31$ cans)
2. A papel picado banner is 12 feet long. Each paper flag is $\frac{3}{4}$ of a foot wide. How many flags are on the banner? (Answer: 16 flags)

3. An art festival has 85 booths. Each booth pays \$125 for their space. How much money does the festival collect from booths? (Answer: \$10,625)
4. (Gr 4-5) A muralist works 6.5 hours per day. She works on a mural for 8 days. How many total hours does she work? If she earns \$22 per hour, how much does she earn? (Answer: 52 hours; \$1,144)
5. (Gr 5) A pottery artist makes 36 pieces. She sells $\frac{2}{3}$ at a market for \$18 each and donates the rest. How much money does she earn? (Answer: 24 pieces $\times$ \$18 = \$432)

Culture Connection Activity

My Culture Connection

After reading the passages, reflect:

1. What is something from your own culture or family that you are proud of?

2. Name one thing you learned about Mexican-American culture that you didn't know before: _____
3. How is Tejano culture similar to or different from your own family traditions? _____
4. Draw or describe a food, tradition, or celebration from YOUR culture:

[Drawing/Writing space]

Spanish/English Cognate Vocabulary Cards

Spanish	English	Definition
celebración	celebration	a party or event honoring something
cultura	culture	the traditions, arts, and beliefs of a group
música	music	the art of organized sound

Spanish	English	Definition
artista	artist	a person who creates art
tradición	tradition	a custom passed down over time
familia	family	a group of related people
comunidad	community	a group of people living in the same area
historia	history	the study of past events
educación	education	the process of learning
independencia	independence	freedom from outside control

Google Slides Version Outline

- Slide 1: Title — Papel picado banner border, vibrant colors
- Slides 2-5: Reading passages (one per slide, scrollable text)
- Slides 6-9: Comprehension questions (editable answer boxes)
- Slides 10-13: Math word problem sets (one per set)
- Slide 14: Culture Connection reflection
- Slide 15: Cognate vocabulary cards
- Slide 16: Writing prompt page